

Jonah: The Reluctant Prophet and the Relentless Mercy of God

A man runs from God because he is afraid God will be kind to the wrong people.

Text. Jonah 1 to 4

Good for. Religious people who quietly want grace for themselves and judgment for others

The arc. Jonah is not mainly about a fish. It is about a prophet whose theology is correct and whose heart is wrong, and a God whose mercy chases both the pagan city and the angry servant who resents it.

1. The Prophet Who Ran

Jonah 1:1-16

Big idea. Jonah flees the call of God and the pagan sailors fear the Lord more readily than the prophet who serves Him.

Aim. To make the hearer ask where they are sailing to avoid what God has said.

Notes

2. Out of the Belly of Sheol

Jonah 1:17 to 2:10

Big idea. In the place of death Jonah prays, and salvation belongs to the Lord who hears even the runaway from the grave.

Aim. To assure the hearer that the bottom is not beyond the reach of grace.

Notes

3. A City Spared

Jonah 3:1-10

Big idea. The reluctant prophet preaches a bare warning and a whole city repents, proving the word does the work, not the messenger's heart.

Aim. To enlarge the hearer's expectation of what God will do with a faithful word.

Notes

4. The Anger of a Saved Man

Jonah 4:1-11

Big idea. Jonah is furious that God is gracious, and the book ends with a question that exposes a heart that loves a plant more than a city.

Aim. To leave the hearer inside Jonah's unanswered question about whom they want God to love.

Notes

HOW TO USE THIS SERIES

These are starting points, not scripts. Each series gives you the arc, the divisions, and a working aim for every sermon, but the breakdown here is scaffolding you will take down once the text has done its own work in you. Read the whole book before you preach the first week of it. Let the passage divisions teach you where the seams actually are.

The text sets the agenda. Not the felt needs you arrived with, not the outline that looks clean on a slide, not the application you already know you want to land. Sit under the passage long enough for it to surprise you, and then preach what it says rather than what you planned. A big idea you did not have to fight for is usually one the text did not give you.